

Heracles

ΕΥΡΙΠΙΔΟΥ ΗΡΑΚΛΗΣ

Euripides

translated by E. P. Coleridge (1891), modernised by Perseus

Plato Scroll · plato-scroll.com



Scan to read online, free and offline
plato-scroll.com/s/eur-heracles/

Heracles

1

At the entrance of Heracles' house in Thebes, before the altar of Zeus.

AMPHITRYON: What mortal has not heard of the one who shared a wife with Zeus, Amphitryon of Argos, whom once Alcaeus, son of Perseus, begot, Amphitryon the father of Heracles? Who lived here in Thebes, where from the sowing of the dragon's teeth grew up a crop of earth-born giants; and of these Ares saved a scanty band, and their children's children people the city of Cadmus. Hence sprung Creon, son of Menoeceus, king of this land; and Creon became the father of this lady Megara, whom once all Cadmus' race escorted with the glad music of lutes at her wedding, when the famous Heracles led her to my halls. Now he, my son, left Thebes where I was settled, left his wife Megara and her kin, eager to make his home in Argolis, in that walled town which the Cyclopes built, from which I am exiled for the slaying of Electryon; so he, wishing to lighten my affliction and to find a home in his own land, offered Eurystheus a mighty price for my recall: to free the world of savage monsters, whether it was that Hera goaded him to submit to this, or that fate was leagued against him. Other toils he has accomplished, and last of all has he passed through the mouth of Taenarus into the halls of Hades to drag to the light that hound with three bodies, and from there he has never returned. Now there is an ancient legend among the race of Cadmus that a certain Lycus in days gone by was husband to Dirce, and he was king of this city with its seven towers, before Amphion and Zethus, sons of Zeus, lords of the milk-white steeds, became rulers in the land. His son, called by the same name as his father, although no Theban but a stranger from Euboea, slew Creon, and after that seized the government, having fallen on this city when weakened by dissension. So this family connection with Creon is likely to prove to us a serious evil; for now that my son is in the bowels of the earth, this new monarch Lycus is

bent on extirpating the children of Heracles, to quench one bloody feud with another, likewise his wife and me, if useless age like mine is to rank among men, that the boys may never grow up to exact a blood-penalty of their uncle's family. So I, left here by my son, while he is gone into the pitchy darkness of the earth, to tend and guard his children in his house, am taking my place with their mother, that the race of Heracles may not perish, here at the altar of Zeus the Savior, which my own gallant child set up to commemorate his glorious victory over the Minyae. And here we are careful to keep our station, though in need of everything, of food, drink and clothes, huddled together on the hard bare ground; for we are barred out from our house and sit here for want of any other safety. As for friends, some I see are unreliable; while others, who are staunch, have no power to help us further. This is what misfortune means to man; may it never fall to the lot of any who bears the least goodwill to me, to apply this never-failing test of friendship!

60

MEGARA: Old warrior, who once razed the citadel of the Taphians leading on the troops of Thebes to glory, how uncertain are the gods' dealings with man! I, for instance, as far as concerned my father, was never an outcast of fortune, for he was once accounted a man of might by reason of his wealth, possessed as he was of royal power, for which long spears are launched at the lives of the fortunate through love of it; children too he had; and he gave me to your son, matching me in glorious marriage with Heracles. And now all that is dead and gone from us; and I and you, old friend, are doomed to die, and these children of Heracles, whom I am guarding beneath my wing as a bird keeps her tender chicks under her. And they one after another keep asking me: "Mother, tell us, where is our father gone from the land? what is he doing? when will he return?" Thus they inquire for their father, in childish perplexity; while I put them off with excuses, inventing stories; but still I wonder if it is he whenever a door creaks on its hinges, and up they all start, thinking to embrace their father's

knees. What hope or way of salvation are you now devising, old friend? for I look to you. We can never steal beyond the boundaries of the land unseen, for there is too strict a watch set on us at every outlet, nor have we any longer hopes of safety in our friends. Whatever your scheme is, declare it, lest our death be made ready.

88

AMPHITRYON: It is by no means easy, my daughter, to give one's earnest advice on such matters off hand, without weary thought; but let us prolong the time, since we are powerless to escape.

90

MEGARA: Do you need a further taste of grief, or do you cling so fast to life?

91

AMPHITRYON: Yes, I love this life, and cling to its hopes.

92

MEGARA: So do I; but you should not expect the unexpected, old friend.

93

AMPHITRYON: In these delays the only cure for our evils is left.

94

MEGARA: It is the biting pain of that interval I feel so.

95

AMPHITRYON: Daughter, there may yet be a happy escape from present troubles for me and you; my son, your husband, may yet arrive. So calm yourself, and wipe those tears from your children's eyes, and soothe them with soft words, inventing a tale to delude them, piteous though such fraud be. Yes, for even men's misfortunes often flag, and the stormy wind does not always blow so strong, nor are the prosperous ever so; for all things change, making way for each other. The bravest man is he who relies ever on his hopes, but despair is the mark of a coward.

107

CHORUS: To the sheltering roof, to the old man's couch, leaning on my staff have I set forth, chanting a plaintive dirge like some bird grown grey, I that am only a voice and a fancy bred of the visions of sleep by night, palsied with age, yet meaning kindly. All hail! you orphaned children! all hail, old friend! you too, unhappy mother, wailing for your husband in the halls of Hades!

119

CHORUS: Do not faint too soon upon your way, or let your limbs grow weary, as a colt beneath the yoke grows weary as he mounts some stony hill, dragging the weight of a wheeled chariot. Take hold of hand or robe, who ever feels his footsteps falter. Old friend, escort another like yourself, who once amid his toiling peers in the days of our youth would take his place beside you, no blot upon his country's glorious record.

130

CHORUS: See, how like their father's sternly flash these children's eyes! Misfortune has not failed his children, nor yet has his comeliness been denied them. O Hellas! if you lose these, of what allies will you rob yourself!

138

CHORUS: But I see Lycus, the ruler of this land, drawing near the house.

140

LYCUS: One question, if I may, to this father of Heracles and his wife; and certainly as your lord and master I have a right to put what questions I choose. How long do you seek to prolong your lives? What hope, what aid do you see to save you from death? Do you trust that these children's father, who lies dead in the halls of Hades, will return? How unworthily you show your sorrow at having to die, you (*to Amphitryon*) after your idle boasts, scattered broadcast through Hellas, that Zeus was partner in your marriage-bed and was your partner in children; and you, (*to Megara*) after calling yourself the wife of so peerless a lord. After all, what was the fine exploit your husband

achieved, if he *did* kill a water-snake in a marsh or that monster of Nemea? which he caught in a snare, for all he says he strangled it to death in his arms. Are these your weapons for the hard struggle? Is it for this then that Heracles' children should be spared? A man who has won a reputation for valor in his contests with beasts, in all else a weakling; who never buckled shield to arm nor faced the spear, but with a bow, that coward's weapon, was ever ready to run away. Archery is no test of manly bravery; no! he is a man who keeps his post in the ranks and steadily faces the swift wound the spear may plough. My policy, again, old man, shows no reckless cruelty, but caution; for I am well aware I slew Creon, the father of this woman, and am in possession of his throne. So I have no wish that these children should grow up and be left to take vengeance on me in requital for what I have done.

170

AMPHITRYON: Let Zeus defend his his own share in his son; but as for me, Heracles, it is my concern on your behalf to prove by what I say this tyrant's ignorance; for I cannot allow you to be ill spoken of. First then for that which should never have been said—for to speak of you, Heracles, as a coward is, I think, outside the pale of speech—of that must I clear you with heaven to witness. I appeal then to the thunder of Zeus, and the chariot in which he rode, when he pierced the Giants, earth's brood, to the heart with his winged shafts, and with gods uplifted the glorious triumph song; or go to Pholoe and ask the insolent tribe of four-legged Centaurs, you craven king, ask them who they would judge the bravest of men; will they not say my son, who according to you is but a pretender? Were you to ask Euboean Dirphys, your native place, it would not sing your praise, for you have never done a single gallant deed to which your country can witness. Next you disparage that clever invention, an archer's weapon; come, listen to me and learn wisdom. A man who fights in line is a slave to his weapons, and if his fellow-comrades want for courage he is slain himself through the cowardice of his neighbors, or, if he breaks his

spear, he cannot defend his body from death, having only one means of defence; whereas all who are armed with the trusty bow, though they have but one weapon, yet is it the best; for a man, after discharging countless arrows, still has others with which to defend himself from death, and standing at a distance keeps off the enemy, wounding them for all their watchfulness with invisible shafts, and never exposing himself to the foe, but keeping under cover; and this is by far the wisest course in battle, to harm the enemy and keep safe oneself, independent of chance. These arguments completely contradict yours with regard to the matter at issue. Next, why are you desirous of slaying these children? What have they done to you? One piece of wisdom I credit you with, your coward terror of a brave man's descendants. Still it is hard on us, if for your cowardice we must die; a fate that ought to have overtaken you at our braver hands, if Zeus had been fairly disposed towards us. But, if you are so anxious to make yourself supreme in the land, let us go into exile; abstain from all violence, else you will suffer by it whenever the god causes fortune's breeze to veer round.

217

AMPHITRYON: Ah! you land of Cadmus—for to you too will I turn, distributing my words of reproach—is this your defense of Heracles and his children? the man who faced alone all the Minyans in battle and allowed Thebes to see the light with free eyes. I cannot praise Hellas, nor will I ever keep silence, finding her so craven as regards my son; she should have come with fire and sword and warrior's arms to help these tender chicks, to requite him for all his labors in purging land and sea. Such help, my children, neither Hellas nor the city of Thebes affords you; to me a feeble friend you look, and I am empty sound and nothing more. For the vigor which once I had, has gone from me; my limbs are palsied with age, and my strength is decayed. If I were young and still powerful in body, I would have seized my spear and dabbled those flaxen locks of his with blood, so that the coward would now be flying from my spear beyond the bounds of Atlas.

236

CHORUS LEADER: Have not the brave among mankind a fair occasion for speech, although slow to begin?

238

LYCUS: Say what you will of me in your exalted phrase, but I by deeds will make you rue those words. (*Calling to his servants*) Go, some to Helicon, others to the glens of Parnassus, and bid woodmen to cut me logs of oak, and when they are brought to the town, pile up a stack of wood all round the altar on either side, and set fire to it and burn them all alive, that they may learn that the dead no longer rules this land, but that for the present I am king. (*Angrily to the Chorus*) As for you, old men, since you thwart my views, not for the children of Heracles alone shall you lament, but likewise for your own misfortunes, and you shall never forget you are slaves and I your prince.

252

CHORUS: —You sons of Earth, whom Ares once sowed, when from the dragon's ravining jaw he had torn the teeth, up with your staves, on which you lean your hands, and dash out this villain's brains! a fellow who, without even being a Theban, but a foreigner, lords it shamefully over the younger men; but my master shall you never be to your joy. —Nor shall you reap the harvest of all my toil; Go back to where you came from, in your insolence. For never while I live, shall you slay these sons of Heracles; not so deep beneath the earth has their father disappeared from his children's ken. —You are in possession of this land which you have ruined, while he, its benefactor, has missed his just reward. —And yet do I take too much upon myself because I help those I love after their death, when most they need a friend? —Ah! right hand, how you desire to wield the spear, but your weakness is a death-blow to your desire. For then I would have stopped you calling me slave, and I would have governed Thebes with credit. In which you now rejoice; for a city sick with dissension and evil counsels does not think aright; otherwise it would never have accepted you as its master.

275

MEGARA: Old men, I thank you; it is right that friends should feel virtuous indignation on behalf of those they love; but do not on our account vent your anger on the tyrant to your own undoing. Hear my advice, Amphitryon, if there appears to you to be anything in what I say. I love my children; strange if I did not love those whom I bore, whom I labored for! Death I count a dreadful fate; but the man who strives against necessity I esteem a fool. Since we must die, let us do so without being burnt alive, a source of mockery to our enemies, which to my mind is an evil worse than death; for much good do we owe our family. You have always had a warrior's fair fame, so it is not to be endured that you should die a coward's death; and my husband's reputation needs no one to witness that he would never consent to save these children's lives by letting them incur the stain of cowardice; for the noble are afflicted by disgrace on account of their children, nor must I shrink from following my lord's example.

295

MEGARA: As to your hopes consider how I weigh them. Do you think your son will return from beneath the earth? And who ever has come back from the dead out of the halls of Hades? But would you soften this man by entreaty? Oh no! better to fly from one's enemy when he is so brutish, but yield to men of breeding and culture; for you would more easily conclude a friendly truce by accepting regard. True, a thought has already occurred to me that we might by entreaty obtain a sentence of exile for the children; yet this too is misery, to compass their deliverance with dire penury as the result; for it is a saying that hosts look sweetly on banished friends for a day and no more. Endure to die with us, for that awaits you after all. By your brave soul I challenge you, old friend; for whoever struggles hard to escape destiny sent by the gods shows zeal no doubt, but it is zeal with a taint of folly; for what must be, no one will ever avail to alter.

312

CHORUS LEADER: If a man had insulted you, while yet my arms were strong, there would have been an easy way to stop him; but now am I am nothing; and so you henceforth, Amphitryon, must scheme how to avert misfortune.

316

AMPHITRYON: It is not cowardice or any longing for life that hinders my dying, but my wish to save my son's children, though no doubt I am longing for the impossible. See! here is my neck ready for the sword to pierce, to hack, to hurl from the rock; only one favor I crave for both of us, king; slay me and this hapless mother before you slay the children, that we may not see the hideous sight, as they gasp out their lives, calling on their mother and their father's father; for the rest work your will if so you are inclined; for we have no defense against death.

327

MEGARA: I too implore you add a second favor, that by your single act you may put us both under a double obligation; allow me to deck my children in the robes of death, first opening the palace gates, for now we are shut out, so that this at least they may obtain from their father's halls.

332

LYCUS: I grant it, and bid my servants undo the bolts. Go in and deck yourselves; robes do not grudge. But as soon as you have clothed yourselves, I will return to you to consign you to the nether world.

Exit Lycus.

336

MEGARA: Children, follow the footsteps of your hapless mother to your father's house, where others possess his substance, though his name is still ours.

Exit Megara with her children.

339

AMPHITRYON: O Zeus, in vain, it seems, did I get you to share my bride with me; in vain used we to call you partner in my son. After all you are less our friend than you pretended. Great god as you are, I, a mortal, surpass you in true worth. For I did not betray the children of Heracles; but you by stealth found your way to my bed, taking another's wife without leave given, while to save your own friends you have no skill. Either you are a god of little sense, or else naturally unjust.

Exit Amphitryon.

348

CHORUS: Phoebus is singing a dirge, after his happier strains, for Linus dead in his beauty, striking his lyre with key of gold; but I wish to sing a song of praise, a crown to all his toil, on the one who has gone to the gloom beneath the nether world, whether I am to call him son of Zeus or of Amphitryon. For the virtue of noble toils is a glory to the dead.

359

CHORUS: First he cleared the grove of Zeus of a lion, and put its skin upon his back, hiding his auburn hair in its fearful gaping jaws.

364

CHORUS: And then one day with murderous bow he wounded the race of wild Centaurs, that range the hills, slaying them with winged shafts. Peneus, the river of fair eddies, knows him well, and those far fields unharvested, and the steadings on Pelion and neighboring caves of Homole, from where the Centaurs rode forth to conquer Thessaly, arming themselves with pines.

375

CHORUS: And he slew that dappled deer with horns of gold, that preyed upon the country-folk, glorifying Artemis, huntress queen of Oenoe.

380

CHORUS: Next he mounted on a chariot and tamed with the bit the horses of Diomedes, that greedily champed their bloody food at gory mangers with unbridled jaws, devouring with hideous joy the flesh of men; then crossing the heights of Hebrus that flow with silver, he still toiled on for the tyrant of Mycenae.

389

CHORUS: And at the strand of the Pelian gulf by the streams of Anaurus, he slew with his arrows Cynus, murderer of his guests, the savage wretch who dwelt in Amphanae.

394

CHORUS: And he came to those minstrel maids, to their orchard in the west, to pluck from the leafy apple-tree its golden fruit, when he had slain the tawny dragon, whose terrible coils were twined all round to guard it; and he made his way into ocean's lairs, bringing calm to men that use the oar.

403

CHORUS: And he stretched out his hands to uphold the firmament, seeking the home of Atlas, and on his manly shoulders took the starry mansions of the gods.

408

CHORUS: Then he went through the waves of heaving Euxine against the mounted host of Amazons dwelling round Maeotis, the lake that is fed by many a stream, having gathered to his standard all his friends from Hellas, to fetch the gold-embroidered raiment of the warrior queen, a deadly quest for a girdle. Hellas won those glorious spoils of the barbarian maid, and they are safe in Mycenae.

419

CHORUS: He burned to ashes Lerna's murderous hound, the many-headed water-snake, and smeared its venom on his darts, with which he slew the shepherd of Erytheia, a monster with three bodies.

425

CHORUS: And many another glorious achievement he brought to a happy issue; to Hades' house of tears has he now sailed, the goal of his

labors, where he is ending his career of toil, nor does he come back again. Now your house is left without a friend, and Charon's boat awaits your children to bear them on that journey out of life, without return, contrary to the gods' law and man's justice; and it is to your prowess that your house is looking although you are not here.

436

CHORUS: Had I been strong and lusty, able to brandish the spear in battle's onset, and my Theban companions too, I would have stood by your children to champion them; but now my happy youth is gone and I am left.

442

CHORUS LEADER: But look! I see the children of Heracles who was once so great, wearing the clothes of the dead, and his loving wife dragging her babes along at her side, and Heracles' aged father. Ah! woe is me! no longer can I stem the flood of tears that spring to my old eyes.

451

MEGARA: Come now, who is to sacrifice or butcher these poor children? [or rob me of my wretched life?] These victims are ready to be led to Hades' halls. O my children! an ill-matched company are we hurried off to die, old men and young ones and mothers, all together. Alas! for my sad fate and my children's, whom these eyes now for the last time behold. So I gave you birth and reared you only for our foes to mock, to jeer at, and slay. Ah me! how bitterly my hopes have disappointed me in the expectation I once formed from the words of your father. (*Addressing each of her three sons in turn.*) To you your dead father was for giving Argos; and you were to dwell in the halls of Eurystheus, lording it over the fair fruitful land of Argolis; and over your head would he throw that lion's skin with which he himself was armed. And you were to be king of Thebes, famed for its chariots, receiving as your heritage my broad lands, for so you coaxed your dear father; and to your hand he used to resign the carved club, his sure defence, pretending to give it to you. And to you he promised to

give Oechalia, which once his archery had wasted. Thus with three principalities would your father exalt you, his three sons, proud of your manliness; while I was choosing the best brides for you, scheming to link you by marriage to Athens, Thebes, and Sparta, that you might live a happy life with a fast sheet-anchor to hold by. And now that is all vanished; fortune's breeze has veered and given to you for brides the maidens of death in their stead, and my tears will be the marriage bath; woe is me for my foolish thoughts! and your grandfather here is celebrating your marriage-feast, the cares of a father, accepting Hades as the father of your brides. Ah me! which of you shall I first press to my bosom, which last? on which bestow my kiss, or clasp close to me? Oh! would that like the bee with russet wing, I could collect from every source my sighs in one, and, blending them together, shed them in one copious flood! O my dearest Heracles, to you I call, if perhaps mortal voice can make itself heard in Hades' halls; your father and children are dying, and I am doomed, I who once because of you was counted blessed as men count bliss. Come to our rescue; appear, I pray, if only as a phantom, since your arrival, even as a dream, would be enough, for they are cowards who are slaying your children.

497

AMPHITRYON: Lady, prepare the funeral rites; but I, O Zeus, stretching out my hand to heaven, call on you to help these children, if such is your intention; for soon any aid of yours will be unavailing; and yet you have been often invoked; my toil is in vain; death seems inevitable. You aged friends, the joys of life are few; so take heed that you pass through it as gladly as you may, without a thought of sorrow from morning until night; for time takes little heed of preserving our hopes; and, when he has busied himself on his own business, away he flies. Look at me, a man who had made a mark among his fellows by deeds of note; yet fortune in a single day has robbed me of it as of a feather that floats away toward the sky. I know not any whose

plenteous wealth and high reputation is fixed and sure; fare you well, for now you have seen the last of your old friend, my comrades.

514

MEGARA: Ah! Old friend, is it my own, my dearest I see? or what am I to say?

515

AMPHITRYON: I do not know, my daughter; I too am struck dumb.

516

MEGARA: Is this he who they told us was beneath the earth? It is, unless some day-dream mocks our sight. What am I saying? What visions do these anxious eyes behold? Old man, this is no one other than your own son. Come here, my children, cling to your father's robe, hurry, never loose your hold, for here is one to help you, not at all behind our savior Zeus.

523

HERACLES: All hail! my house and gates of my home, how glad I am to emerge to the light and see you. Ah! what is this? I see my children before the house in the robes of death, with chaplets on their heads and my wife amid a throng of men, and my father weeping—what misfortune? Let me draw near to them and inquire; lady, what strange stroke of fate has fallen on the house?

531

MEGARA: Dearest of all mankind to me!

AMPHITRYON: O ray of light appearing to your father!

532

MEGARA: Are you safe and is your coming just in time to help your dear ones?

533

HERACLES: What do you mean? What is this confusion I find on my arrival, father?

534

MEGARA: We are being ruined; forgive me, old friend, if I have anticipated that to which you had a right to tell him; for women's nature is perhaps more prone to grief than men's and they are my children that were being led to death, which was my own lot too.

538

HERACLES: Apollo! what a prelude to your story!

539

MEGARA: My brothers are dead, and my old father.

540

HERACLES: How so? what did he do? whose spear did he meet?

541

MEGARA: Lycus, our new monarch, slew him.

542

HERACLES: Did he meet him in fair fight, or was the land sick and weak?

543

MEGARA: Yes, from faction; now he is master of the city of Cadmus with its seven gates.

544

HERACLES: Why has panic fallen on you and my aged father?

545

MEGARA: He meant to kill your father, me, and my children.

546

HERACLES: What are you saying? What did he have to fear from my orphan babes?

547

MEGARA: He was afraid they might some day avenge Creon's death.

548

HERACLES: What is this dress they wear, suited to the dead?

549

MEGARA: It is the garb of death we have already put on.

550

HERACLES: And were you being forced to die? O woe is me!

551

MEGARA: Yes, deserted by every friend, and informed that you were dead.

552

HERACLES: What put such desperate thoughts into your heads?

553

MEGARA: That was what the heralds of Eurystheus kept proclaiming.

554

HERACLES: Why did you leave my hearth and home?

555

MEGARA: He forced us; your father was dragged from his bed.

556

HERACLES: Had he no shame, to ill-use the old man so?

557

MEGARA: Shame indeed! that goddess and he dwell far enough apart.

558

HERACLES: Was I so poor in friends in my absence?

559

MEGARA: Who are the friends of a man in misfortune?

560

HERACLES: Do they make so light of my hard warring with the Minyans?

561

MEGARA: Misfortune, to repeat it to you, has no friends.

562

HERACLES: Cast from your heads these chaplets of death, look up to the light, for instead of the darkness below your eyes behold the welcome sun. I, meanwhile, since here is work for my hand, will first go raze this upstart tyrant's halls, and when I have beheaded the villain, I will throw him to dogs to tear; and every Theban who I find has played the traitor after my kindness, will I destroy with this

victorious club; the rest will I tear apart with my feathered shafts and fill Ismenus full of bloody corpses, and Dirce's clear stream shall run red with gore. For whom ought I to help rather than wife and children and aged father? Farewell my labors! for it was in vain I accomplished them rather than helping these. And yet I ought to die in their defence, since they for their father were doomed; or what shall we find so noble in having fought a hydra and a lion at the commands of Eurystheus, if I make no effort to save my own children from death? No longer then, as before, shall I be called Heracles the victor.

583

CHORUS LEADER: It is only right that parents should help their children, their aged fathers, and the partners of their marriage.

585

AMPHITRYON: My son, it is like you to show your love for your dear ones and your hate for your enemies; only curb excessive hastiness.

587

HERACLES: How, father, am I now showing more than fitting haste?

588

AMPHITRYON: The king has a host of allies, needy villains though pretending to be rich, who sowed dissension and overthrew the state with a view to plundering their neighbors; for the wealth they had in their houses was all spent, dissipated by their sloth. You were seen entering the city; and, that being so, beware that you do not bring your enemies together and be slain unawares.

595

HERACLES: Little I care if the whole city saw me; but happening to see a bird perched in an unlucky position, from it I learned that some trouble had befallen my house; so on purpose I made my entry to the land by stealth.

599

AMPHITRYON: Well done; now, on your arrival, go salute your household altar, and let your father's halls behold your face. For soon the king will be here in person to drag away your wife and children

and murder them, and to add me to the bloody list. But if you remain on the spot all will go well, and you will profit by this security; but do not rouse your city before you have these matters well in train, my son.

606

HERACLES: I will do so; your advice is good; I will enter my house. After my return at length from the sunless den of Hades and the maiden queen of hell, I will not neglect to greet first of all the gods beneath my roof.

610

AMPHITRYON: Did you really go to the house of Hades, my son?

611

HERACLES: Yes, and brought to the light that three-headed monster.

612

AMPHITRYON: Did you conquer him in fight, or receive him from the goddess?

613

HERACLES: In fight; for I had been lucky enough to witness the rites of the initiated.

614

AMPHITRYON: Is the monster really lodged in the house of Eurystheus?

615

HERACLES: The grove of Demeter and the city of Hermione have him now.

616

AMPHITRYON: Eurystheus does not know that you have returned to the upper world?

617

HERACLES: He does not; I came here first to learn your news.

618

AMPHITRYON: How is it you were so long beneath the earth?

619

HERACLES: I stayed awhile attempting to bring back Theseus from Hades, father.

620

AMPHITRYON: Where is he? gone to his native land?

621

HERACLES: He set out for Athens, glad to have escaped from the lower world. Come now, children, attend your father to the house. My entering in is fairer in your eyes, I think, than my going out. Oh, take heart, and no more let the tears stream from your eyes; you too, my wife, collect your courage, cease from fear; leave go my robe; for I cannot fly away, nor have I any wish to flee from those I love. Ah! they do not loose their hold, but cling to my garments all the more; were you on the razor's edge of danger? Well, I must lead them, taking them by the hand to draw them after me, my little boats, like a ship when towing; for I too do not reject the care of my children; here all mankind are equal; all love their children, both those of high estate and those who are nothing; it is wealth that makes distinctions among them; some have, others want; but all the human race loves its offspring.

Exeunt Heracles and Megara, with their children.

637

CHORUS: Dear to me is youth always, but old age is hanging over my head, a burden heavier than Aetna's crags, casting its pall of gloom upon my eyes. Oh! never may the wealth of Asia's kings tempt me to barter for houses stored with gold my happy youth, which is in wealth and poverty alike most fair! But old age is gloomy and deadly; I hate it; let it sink beneath the waves! Would it had never found its way to the homes and towns of mortal men, but were still drifting on for ever down the wind.

655

CHORUS: Had the gods shown discernment and wisdom, as mortals count these things, men would have won youth twice over, a visible

mark of worth among whomever found, and after death these would have run a double course once more to the sun-light, while the low born would have had a single portion of life; and thus would it have been possible to distinguish the good and the bad, just as sailors know the number of the stars amid the clouds. But, as it is, the gods have set no certain boundary between good and bad, but time's onward roll brings increase only to man's wealth.

673

CHORUS: Never will I cease to link in one the Graces and the Muses, sweetest union. Never may I live among uneducated boors, but ever may I find a place among the crowned! Yes, still the aged singer lifts up his voice of bygone memories: still is my song of the triumphs of Heracles, whether Bromius the giver of wine is near, or the strains of the seven-stringed lyre and the Libyan pipe are rising; not yet will I cease to sing the Muses' praise, my patrons in the dance.

687

CHORUS: The maids of Delos raise their song of joy, circling round the temple gates in honor of Leto's fair son, the graceful dancer; so I with my old lips will cry aloud songs of joy at your palace-doors, like the swan, aged singer; for there is a good theme for minstrelsy; he is the son of Zeus; yet high above his noble birth tower his deeds of prowess, for his toil secured this life of calm for man, having destroyed all fearsome beasts.

701

LYCUS: Amphitryon, it is high time you came forth from the palace; you have been too long arraying yourselves in the robes and trappings of the dead. Come, bid the wife and children of Heracles show themselves outside the house, to die on the conditions you yourselves offered.

707

AMPHITRYON: Lord, you persecute me in my misery and heap insult upon me over and above the loss of my son; you should have been more moderate in your zeal, though you are my lord and master. But

since you impose death's necessity on me, I must acquiesce; what you wish must be done.

712

LYCUS: Now, where is Megara? where are the children of Alcmena's son?

713

AMPHITRYON: She, I believe, so far as I can guess from outside—

714

LYCUS: What grounds do you have to base your fancy on?

715

AMPHITRYON: Is sitting as a suppliant on the altar's hallowed steps—

716

LYCUS: Imploring them quite uselessly to save her life.

717

AMPHITRYON: And calling on her dead husband, in vain.

718

LYCUS: He is nowhere near, and he certainly will never come.

719

AMPHITRYON: No, unless perhaps a god should raise him from the dead.

720

LYCUS: Go to her and bring her from the palace.

721

AMPHITRYON: By doing so I should become an accomplice in her murder.

722

LYCUS: Since you have this scruple, I, who have left fear behind, will myself bring out the mother and her children. Follow me, servants, that we may joyfully put an end to this delay of our work.

Exit Lycus.

726

AMPHITRYON: Then go your way along the path of fate; for what remains, maybe another will provide. Expect for your evil deeds to find some trouble yourself. Ah! my aged friends, he is marching fairly to his doom; soon will he lie entangled in the snare of the sword, thinking to slay his neighbors, the villain! I will go, to see him fall dead; for the sight of a foe being slain and paying the penalty of his misdeeds affords pleasurable feelings.

Exit Amphitryon.

735

CHORUS: Evil has changed sides; he who was once a mighty king is now turning his life backward into the road to Hades. Hail to you! Justice and heavenly retribution. At last have you reached the goal where your death will pay the penalty, for your insults against your betters. Joy makes my tears burst forth. He has come back— which I never once thought in my heart would happen—the prince of the land. Come, old friends, let us look within to see if someone has met the fate I hope.

750

LYCUS: (*within*) Ah me! ah me!

751

CHORUS: Ha! how sweet to hear that opening note of his within the house; death is not far off him now. The prince cries out, wailing a prelude of death.

754

LYCUS: (*within*) O kingdom of Cadmus, I am perishing by treachery!

755

CHORUS: You were yourself for making others perish; endure your retribution; it is only the penalty of your own deeds you are paying. Who was he, only a mortal, that aimed his silly saying at the blessed gods of heaven with impious blasphemy, maintaining that they are weaklings after all? Old friends, our godless foe is now no more. The

house is still; let us turn to the dance. Yes, for fortune smiles upon my friends as I desire.

763

CHORUS: Dances, dances and banquets now prevail throughout the holy town of Thebes. For change from tears, change from sorrow give birth to song. The new king is gone; our former monarch rules, having made his way even from the harbor of Acheron. Hope beyond all expectation is fulfilled.

772

CHORUS: The gods, the gods take care to heed the right and wrong. It is their gold and their good luck that lead men's hearts astray, bringing in their train unjust power. For no man ever had the courage to reflect what reverses Time might bring; but, disregarding law to gratify lawlessness, he shatters the black chariot of prosperity.

781

CHORUS: O Ismenus, deck yourself with garlands! Break forth into dancing, you paved streets of our seven-gated city! come Dirce, fount of waters fair; and joined with her you nymphs of Asopus, come from your father's waves to add your voices to our hymn, the victor's prize that Heracles has won. O Pythian rock with forests crowned, and haunts of the Muses on Helicon! you will come to my city and her walls with cries of joy; where the earth-born crop sprang to view, a warrior-host with shields of brass, who are handing on their realm to children's children, a divine light to Thebes.

798

CHORUS: All hail the marriage! in which two bridegrooms shared; the one, a mortal; the other, Zeus, who came to wed the bride sprung from Perseus; for that marriage of yours, O Zeus, in days gone by has been proved to me a true story beyond all expectation; and time has shown the brightness of Heracles' strength; for he emerged from caverns beneath the earth after leaving Pluto's halls below. To me you are a worthier lord than that base-born king, who now lets it be plainly

seen in this struggle between armed warriors, whether justice still finds favor in heaven.

815

Catching sight of the spectre of Madness.

CHORUS: —Ha! see there, my old comrades! is the same wild panic fallen on us all; what phantom is this I see hovering over the house? — Fly, fly, bestir your tardy steps! begone! away! —O savior prince, avert calamity from me!

822

IRIS: Courage, old men! she, whom you see, is Madness, daughter of Night, and I am Iris, the handmaid of the gods. We have not come to do your city any hurt, but our warfare is against the house of one man only, against him whom they call the son of Zeus and Alcmena. For until he had finished all his grievous labors, Destiny was preserving him, nor would father Zeus ever suffer me or Hera to harm him. But now that he has accomplished the labors of Eurystheus, Hera wishes to brand him with the guilt of shedding kindred blood by slaying his own children, and I wish it also. Come then, unwed maid, child of black Night, harden your heart relentlessly, send forth frenzy upon this man, confound his mind even to the slaying of his children, drive him, goad him wildly on his mad career, shake out the sails of death, that when he has conveyed over Acheron's ferry that fair group of children by his own murderous hand, he may learn to know how fiercely against him the wrath of Hera burns and may also experience mine; otherwise, if he should escape punishment, the gods will become as nothing, while man's power will grow.

843

MADNESS: Of noble parents was I born, the daughter of Night, sprung from the blood of Ouranos; and these prerogatives I hold, not to use them in anger against friends, nor do I have any joy in visiting the homes of men; and I wish to counsel Hera, before I see her make a mistake, and you too, if you will hearken to my words. This man, against whose house you are sending me, has made himself a name

alike in heaven and earth; for, after taming pathless wilds and raging sea, he by his single might raised up again the honors of the gods when sinking before man's impiety; ... wherefore I counsel you, do not wish him dire mishaps.

855

IRIS: Spare us your advice on Hera's and my schemes.

856

MADNESS: I seek to turn your steps into the best path instead of into this one of evil.

857

IRIS: It was not to practice self-control that the wife of Zeus sent you here.

858

MADNESS: I call the sun-god to witness that here I am acting against my will; but if indeed I must at once serve you and Hera and follow you in full cry as hounds follow the huntsman, then I will go; neither ocean with its fiercely groaning waves, nor the earthquake, nor the thunderbolt with blast of agony shall be like the headlong rush I will make into the breast of Heracles; through his roof will I burst my way and swoop upon his house, after first slaying his children; nor shall their murderer know that he is killing the children he begot, till he is released from my madness. Behold him! see how even now he is wildly tossing his head at the outset, and rolling his eyes fiercely from side to side without a word; nor can he control his panting breath, like a fearful bull in act to charge; he bellows, calling on the goddesses of nether hell. Soon will I rouse you to yet wilder dancing and pipe a note of terror in your ear. Soar away, O Iris, to Olympus on your honored course; while I unseen will steal into the halls of Heracles.

875

CHORUS: Alas alas! lament; the son of Zeus, flower of your city, is being cut down. Woe to you, Hellas! that will cast from you your benefactor, and destroy him as he dances in the shrill frenzy of Madness. She is mounted on her chariot, the queen of sorrow and

sighing, and is goading on her steeds, as if for outrage, the Gorgon child of Night, with a hundred hissing serpent-heads, Madness of the flashing eyes. Soon has the god changed his good fortune; soon will his children breathe their last, slain by a father's hand.

887

AMPHITRYON: Ah me! alas!

888

CHORUS: O Zeus, unjust Vengeance, mad, relentless, will soon give your childless son up to misery.

890

AMPHITRYON: Alas, O house!

891

CHORUS: The dance begins without the cymbals' crash, with no glad waving of the wine-god's staff—

893

AMPHITRYON: Woe to these halls!

894

CHORUS: Toward bloodshed, and not to pour libations of Dionysus' grape.

896

AMPHITRYON: O children, make haste to fly!

CHORUS: That is the chant of death, of death, to the music of pipes. Ah, yes! he is hunting the children down. Never will Madness lead her revel rout in vain.

900

AMPHITRYON: Ah misery!

901

CHORUS: Ah me! how I lament that aged father, that mother too that bore his children in vain. Look! look! A tempest rocks the house; the roof is falling with it.

906

HERACLES: Oh, oh! what are you doing, Pallas, child of Zeus, to the house? You are sending hell's confusion against the halls, as once you did on Enceladus.

910

MESSENGER: O white-haired old men!

CHORUS: Why this loud address to me?

911

MESSENGER: It is dreadful within!

CHORUS: No need for me to call another prophet for that.

913

MESSENGER: The children are dead.

CHORUS: Alas!

914

MESSENGER: Ah weep! for here is cause for weeping.

CHORUS: A cruel murder, cruel parents' hands!

916

MESSENGER: No words can utter more than we have suffered.

917

CHORUS: How came the ruin you reveal, the ruin that must be lamented, from a father to his children? Tell me how these heaven-sent woes came rushing on the house; say how the children met their sad mischance.

922

MESSENGER: Victims to purify the house were stationed before the altar of Zeus, for Heracles had slain and cast from his halls the king of the land. There stood his group of lovely children, with his father and Megara; and already the basket was being passed round the altar, and we were keeping holy silence. But just as Alcmena's son was bringing the torch in his right hand to dip it in the holy water, he stopped without a word. And as their father lingered, his children looked at him; he was no longer himself; his eyes were rolling; he was quite

distraught; his eyeballs were bloodshot, and foam was oozing down his bearded cheek. He spoke with a madman's laugh: "Father, why should I offer the purifying flame before I have slain Eurystheus, and have the toil twice over? It is the work of my unaided arm to settle these things well; as soon as I have brought the head of Eurystheus here, I will cleanse my hands for those already slain. Spill the water, cast the baskets from your hands. Ho! give me now my bow and club! To Mycenae will I go; I must take crow-bars and pick-axes, for I will shatter again with iron levers those city-walls which the Cyclopes squared with red plumb-line and mason's tools."

947

MESSENGER: Then he set out, and though he had no chariot there, he thought he had, and was for mounting to its seat, and using a goad as though his fingers really held one. A twofold feeling filled his servants' breasts, amusement and fear at once; and one looking to his neighbor said: "Is our master making sport for us, or is he mad?" But he was pacing to and fro in his house; and, rushing into the men's chamber, he said he had reached the city of Nisus; and going into the house, he threw himself upon the floor, as he was, and made ready to feast. But after waiting a brief space he began saying he was on his way to the plains amid the valleys of the Isthmus; and then stripping himself of his mantle, he fell to competing with no one, and he proclaimed himself victor with his own voice, calling on no one to listen. Next, fancy carrying him to Mycenae, he was uttering fearful threats against Eurystheus. Meantime his father caught him by his stalwart arm, and thus addressed him: "My son, what do you mean by this? What strange doings are these? Can it be that the blood of your late victims has driven you frantic?" But he, supposing it was the father of Eurystheus striving in abject supplication to touch his hand: thrust him aside, and then against his own children aimed his bow and made ready his quiver, thinking to slay the sons of Eurystheus. And they in wild fright darted here and there, one to his hapless mother's skirts, another to the shadow of a pillar, while a third cowered

beneath the altar like a bird. Then cried their mother: "O you who begot them, what are you doing? do you mean to slay your children?" Likewise his aged father and all the gathered servants cried aloud. But he, hunting the child round and round the column, in dreadful circles, and coming face to face with him shot him to the heart; and he fell upon his back, sprinkling the stone pillars with blood as he gasped out his life. Then Heracles shouted in triumph and boasted loud: "Here lies one of Eurystheus' brood dead at my feet, atoning for his father's hatred." Then he aimed his bow against a second, who had crouched at the altar's foot thinking to escape unseen. But before he fired, the poor child threw himself at his father's knees, and, flinging his hand to reach his beard or neck, cried: "Oh! hear me, dearest father, do not kill me! I am your child, your own; it is no son of Eurystheus you will slay."

990

MESSENGER: But that other, with savage Gorgon-sowl, as the child now stood in range of his baleful archery, smote him on the head, as a smith strikes his molten iron, bringing down his club upon the fair-haired boy, and crushed the bones. The second caught, away he goes to add a third victim to the other two. But before he could, the poor mother caught up her child and carried him within the house and shut the doors. But he, as though he really were at the Cyclopean walls, prized open the doors with levers, and, hurling down their posts, with one shaft laid low his wife and child. Then in wild gallop he starts to slay his aged father; but there came a phantom, as it seemed to us on-lookers, of Pallas, with plumed helm, brandishing a spear; and she hurled a rock against the breast of Heracles, which held him from his frenzied thirst for blood and plunged him into sleep; to the ground he fell, striking his back against a column that had fallen on the floor shattered in two when the roof fell in. Then we rallied from our flight, and with the old man's aid bound him fast with knotted cords to the pillar, so that on his awakening he might do no further mischief. So there he sleeps, poor wretch! a sleep that is not blessed,

having murdered wife and children; no, for my part I do not know any mortal more miserable than he.

Exit messenger.

1016

CHORUS: That murder wrought by the daughters of Danaus, which the rock of Argos keeps, was once the most famous and notorious in Hellas; but this has surpassed, has outrun those former horrors ... for the unhappy son of Zeus. I could tell of the murder done by Procne, mother of an only child, offered to the Muses; but you had three children, wretched parent, and all of them have you in your frenzy slain. Alas! What groans or wails, what funeral dirge, or dance of death am I to raise? Ah, ah! see, the bolted doors of the lofty palace are being rolled apart. Ah me! see the wretched children lying before their unhappy father, who is sunk in dreadful slumber after shedding their blood. Round him are bonds and cords, made fast with many knots about the body of Heracles, and lashed to the stone columns of his house.

1039

CHORUS LEADER: But he, the aged father, like mother-bird wailing her unfledged brood, comes hastening here with halting steps on his bitter journey.

1042

The palace doors opening disclose Heracles lying asleep, bound to a shattered column.

AMPHITRYON: Softly, softly! you aged sons of Thebes, let him sleep on and forget his sorrows.

1045

CHORUS: For you, old friend, I weep and mourn, for the children too and that victorious chief.

1047

AMPHITRYON: Stand further off, make no noise nor outcry, do not rouse him from his calm deep slumber.

1050

CHORUS: O horrible! all this blood—

1051

AMPHITRYON: Hush, hush! you will be my ruin.

1052

CHORUS: That he has spilled is rising up against him.

1053

AMPHITRYON: Gently raise your dirge of woe, old friends; or he will wake, and, bursting his bonds, destroy the city, rend his father, and dash his house to pieces.

1057

CHORUS: I cannot, cannot—

AMPHITRYON: Hush! let me note his breathing; come, let me put my ear close.

1060

CHORUS: Is he sleeping?

AMPHITRYON: Yes, he is sleeping, a deadly sleepless sleep, having slain wife and children with the arrows of his twanging bow.

1065

CHORUS: Ah! mourn—

AMPHITRYON: Indeed I do.

1066

CHORUS: The children's death—

AMPHITRYON: Ah me!

1067

CHORUS: And your own son's doom.

AMPHITRYON: Alas!

1068

CHORUS: Old friend—

AMPHITRYON: Hush! hush! he is turning over, he is waking! Oh! let me hide myself, concealed beneath the roof.

1071

CHORUS: Courage! darkness still holds your son's eye.

1072

AMPHITRYON: Oh beware! it is not that I shrink from leaving the light after my miseries, poor wretch! but if should he slay me, his father, then he will be devising mischief on mischief, and to the avenging curse will add a parent's blood.

1078

CHORUS: Well for you if you had died in that day, when, for your wife, you went forth to exact vengeance for her slain brothers by sacking the Taphians' sea-beat town.

1081

AMPHITRYON: Fly, fly, my aged friends, from before the palace, escape his waking fury. Or soon he will heap up fresh slaughter on the old, ranging wildly once more through the streets of Thebes.

1086

CHORUS LEADER: O Zeus, why have you shown such savage hate against your own son and plunged him in this sea of troubles?

1088

HERACLES: (*waking*) Aha! I am alive and breathing; and my eyes resume their function, opening on the sky and earth and the sun's darting beam; but how my senses reel! in what strange turmoil am I plunged! my fevered breath in quick spasmodic gasps escapes my lungs. How now? why am I lying here, my brawny chest and arms made fast with cables like a ship, beside a half-shattered piece of masonry, with corpses for my neighbors; while over the floor my bow and arrows are scattered, that once like trusty squires to my arm both kept me safe and were kept safe by me? Surely I have not come a second time to Hades' halls, having just returned from there for Eurystheus? To Hades? From where? No, I do not see Sisyphus with his stone, or Pluto, or his queen, Demeter's child. Surely I am distraught;

where am I, so helpless? Ho, there! which of my friends is near or far to cure me in my perplexity? For I have no clear knowledge of things once familiar.

1109

AMPHITRYON: My aged friends, shall I approach the scene of my sorrow?

1110

CHORUS LEADER: Yes, and let me go with you, not desert you in your trouble.

1111

HERACLES: Father, why do you weep and veil your eyes, standing far from your beloved son?

1113

AMPHITRYON: My child! mine still, for all your misery.

1114

HERACLES: Why, what is there so sad in my case that you weep?

1115

AMPHITRYON: That which might make any of the gods weep, if he were to learn it.

1116

HERACLES: A bold assertion that, but you are not yet explaining what has happened.

1117

AMPHITRYON: Your own eyes see that, if by this time you are restored to your senses.

1118

HERACLES: Fill in your sketch if any change awaits my life.

1119

AMPHITRYON: I will explain, if you are no longer mad as a fiend of hell.

1120

HERACLES: Oh! what suspicions these dark hints of yours again excite!

1121

AMPHITRYON: I am still doubtful whether you are in your sober senses.

1122

HERACLES: I have no recollection of being mad.

1123

AMPHITRYON: Am I to loose my son, old friends, or what shall I do?

1124

HERACLES: Loose me, yes, and say who bound me; for I feel shame at this.

1125

AMPHITRYON: Rest content with what you know of your woes; the rest forego.

1126

HERACLES: No. for is silence sufficient to learn what I wish?

1127

AMPHITRYON: O Zeus, do you behold these deeds proceeding from the throne of Hera?

1128

HERACLES: What! have I suffered something from her enmity?

1129

AMPHITRYON: A truce to the goddess! attend to your own troubles.

1130

HERACLES: I am undone; you will tell me some mischance.

1131

AMPHITRYON: See here the corpses of your children.

1132

HERACLES: O horror! what sight is here? ah me!

1133

AMPHITRYON: My son, against your children you have waged unnatural war.

1134

HERACLES: War! what do you mean? who killed these?

1135

AMPHITRYON: You and your bow and some god, whoever is to blame.

1136

HERACLES: What are you saying? what have I done? Speak, father, you messenger of evil!

1137

AMPHITRYON: You were insane; it is a sad explanation you are asking.

1138

HERACLES: Was it I that slew my wife also?

1139

AMPHITRYON: Your own unaided arm has done all this.

1140

HERACLES: Alas! a cloud of mourning wraps me round.

1141

AMPHITRYON: For this reason I lament your fate.

1142

HERACLES: Did I dash my house to pieces in my frenzy?

1143

AMPHITRYON: I know nothing but this, that you are utterly undone.

1144

HERACLES: Where did the madness seize me? where did it destroy me?

1145

AMPHITRYON: When you were purifying yourself with fire at the altar.

1146

HERACLES: Ah me! why do I spare my own life when I have become the murderer of my dear children? Shall I not hasten to leap from some sheer rock, or aim the sword against my heart and avenge my children's blood, or burn my body, which she drove mad, in the fire and so avert from my life the infamy which now awaits me? But here I

see Theseus coming to check my deadly counsels, my kinsman and friend. Now shall I stand revealed, and the dearest of my friends will see the pollution I have incurred by my children's murder. Ah, woe is me! what am I to do? Where can I find freedom from my sorrows? shall I take wings or plunge beneath the earth? Come, let me veil my head in darkness; for I am ashamed of the evil I have done, and, since for these I have incurred fresh blood-guiltiness, I do not want to harm the innocent.

1163

THESEUS: I have come, and others with me, young warriors from the land of Athens, encamped at present by the streams of Asopus, to bring an allied army to your son, old friend. For a rumour reached the city of the Erechtheidae, that Lycus had usurped the scepter of this land and had become your enemy even to battle. Wherefore I came making recompense for the former kindness of Heracles in saving me from the world below, if you have any need of such aid as I or my allies can give, old man. Ha! why this heap of dead upon the floor? Surely I have not delayed too long and come too late to check a revolution? Who slew these children? whose wife is this I see? Boys do not go to battle; no, it must be some other strange mischance I here discover.

1178

AMPHITRYON: O king, whose home is that olive-clad hill!

1179

THESEUS: Why this piteous prelude in addressing me?

1180

AMPHITRYON: The gods have afflicted us with grievous suffering.

1181

THESEUS: Whose are these children, over whom you weep?

1182

AMPHITRYON: My own son's children, woe is him! he was their father and butcher both, hardening his heart to the bloody deed.

1184

THESEUS: Hush! good words only!

1185

AMPHITRYON: I would I could obey!

1186

THESEUS: What dreadful words!

1187

AMPHITRYON: Fortune has spread her wings, and we are ruined, ruined.

1188

THESEUS: What do you mean? what has he done?

1189

AMPHITRYON: Slain them in a wild fit of frenzy with arrows dipped in the venom of the hundred-headed hydra.

1191

THESEUS: This is Hera's work; but who lies there among the dead, old man?

1192

AMPHITRYON: My son, my own enduring son, that marched with gods to Phlegra's plain, there to battle with giants and slay them, warrior that he was.

1195

THESEUS: Ah, ah! whose fortune was ever so cursed as his?

1196

AMPHITRYON: Never will you find another mortal that has suffered more or been driven harder.

1198

THESEUS: Why does he veil his head, poor wretch, in his robe?

1199

AMPHITRYON: He is ashamed to meet your eye; his kinsman's kind intent and his children's blood make him abashed.

1202

THESEUS: But I come to sympathize; uncover him.

1204

AMPHITRYON: My son, remove that mantle from your eyes, throw it from you, show your face to the sun. As a counterweight, fighting along with my tears, I entreat you as a suppliant, as I grasp your beard, your knees, your hands, and let fall the tear from my old eyes. O my child! restrain your savage lion-like temper, for you are rushing forth on an unholy course of bloodshed, eager to join mischief to mischief, child.

1214

THESEUS: What! Enough! To you I call who are huddled there in your misery, show to your friends your face; for no darkness is black enough to hide your sad mischance. Why do you wave your hand at me, signifying murder? is it that I may not be polluted by speaking with you? If I share your misfortune, what is that to me? For once I had good fortune with you. I must refer to the time when you brought me safe from the dead to the light of life. I hate a friend whose gratitude grows old; one who is ready to enjoy his friends' prosperity but unwilling to sail in the same ship with them when they are unfortunate. Arise, unveil your head, poor wretch! and look on me. The gallant soul endures such blows as heaven deals and does not refuse them.

1229

HERACLES: O Theseus, did you see this struggle with my children?

1230

THESEUS: I heard of it, and now I see the horrors you mean.

1231

HERACLES: Why then have you unveiled my head to the sun?

1232

THESEUS: Why have I? you, a mortal, can not pollute what is of the gods.

1233

HERACLES: Try to escape, luckless wretch, from my unholy taint.

1234

THESEUS: The avenging fiend does not go forth from friend to friend.

1235

HERACLES: For this I thank you; I do not regret the service I did you.

1236

THESEUS: While I, for kindness then received, now show my pity for you.

1237

HERACLES: Ah yes! I am piteous object, a murderer of my sons.

1238

THESEUS: I weep for you in your changed fortunes.

1239

HERACLES: Did you ever find another more afflicted?

1240

THESEUS: Your misfortunes reach from earth to heaven.

1241

HERACLES: Therefore I am resolved on death.

1242

THESEUS: Do you suppose the gods attend to your threats?

1243

HERACLES: The god has been remorseless to me; so I will be the same to the gods.

1244

THESEUS: Hush! lest your presumption add to your sufferings.

1245

HERACLES: My ship is freighted full with sorrow; there is no room to stow anything further.

1246

THESEUS: What will you do? Where is your fury drifting you?

1247

HERACLES: I will die and return to that world below from which I have just come.

1248

THESEUS: Such language is fit for any common fellow.

1249

HERACLES: Ah! yours is the advice of one outside sorrow.

1250

THESEUS: Are these indeed the words of Heracles, the much-enduring?

1251

HERACLES: Though never so much as this. Endurance must have a limit.

1252

THESEUS: Is this the benefactor and great friend to mortals?

1253

HERACLES: Mortals bring no help to me; no! Hera has her way.

1254

THESEUS: Never would Hellas allow you to die through sheer perversity.

1255

HERACLES: Hear me a moment, that I may enter the contest with arguments in answer to your admonitions; and I will unfold to you why life now as well as formerly has been unbearable to me. First I am the son of a man who incurred the guilt of blood, before he married my mother Alcmena, by slaying her aged father. Now when the foundation is badly laid at birth, it is necessary for the race to be cursed with woe; and Zeus, whoever this Zeus may be, begot me as an enemy to Hera; yet do not be vexed, old man; for you rather than Zeus I regard as my father. Then while I was being suckled, that bedfellow of Zeus foisted into my cradle fearsome snakes to cause my death. After I took on a cloak of youthful flesh, of all the toils I then endured what need to tell? what did I not destroy, whether lions, or triple-bodied Typhons, or giants or the battle against the hosts of four-legged Centaurs? or how when I had killed the hydra, that monster with a ring of heads with power to grow again, I passed through a herd

of countless other toils besides and came to the dead to fetch to the light at the bidding of Eurystheus the three-headed hound, hell's porter. Last, ah, woe is me! I have dared this labor, to crown the sorrows of my house with my children's murder. I have come to this point of necessity; no longer may I dwell in Thebes, the city that I love; for suppose I stay, to what temple or gathering of friends shall I go? For mine is no curse that invites greetings. Shall I go to Argos? how can I, when I am an exile from my country? Well, is there a single other city I can rush to? Am I then to be looked at askance as a marked man, held by cruel stabbing tongues: "Is not this the son of Zeus that once murdered children and wife? Plague take him from the land!"

1291

HERACLES: Now to one who was once called happy, such changes are a grievous thing; though he who is always unfortunate feels no such pain, for sorrow is his birthright. This, I think, is the piteous pass I shall one day come to; for earth will cry out forbidding me to touch her, the sea and the river-springs will refuse me a crossing, and I shall become like Ixion who revolves in chains upon that wheel. And so this is best, that I should be seen by no one of the Hellenes, among whom in happier days I lived in bliss. What right have I to live? what profit can I have in the possession of a useless, impious life? So let that noble wife of Zeus dance, beating her foot in its shoe; for now has she worked her heart's desire in utterly confounding the first of Hellas' sons. Who would pray to such a goddess? Her jealousy of Zeus for his love of a woman has destroyed the benefactors of Hellas, guiltless though they were.

1311

CHORUS LEADER: This is the work of none other of the gods than the wife of Zeus; you are right in that surmise.

1313

THESEUS: I cannot counsel you ... rather than to go on suffering. There is not a man alive that has wholly escaped misfortune's taint, nor any god either, if what poets sing is true. Have they not

intermarried in ways that law forbids? Have they not thrown fathers into ignominious chains to gain the sovereign power? Still they inhabit Olympus and brave the issue of their crimes. And yet what shall you say in your defence, if you, a child of man, take your fate excessively hard, while they, as gods, do not? No, then, leave Thebes in compliance with the law, and come with me to the city of Pallas. There, when I have purified you of your pollution, I will give you homes and the half of all I have. Yes, I will give you all those presents I received from the citizens for saving their fourteen children, when I slew the bull of Crete; for I have plots of land assigned me throughout the country; these shall henceforth be called after you by men, while you live; and at your death, when you have gone to Hades' halls, the whole city of Athens shall exalt your honor with sacrifices and a monument of stone. For it is a noble crown of a good reputation for citizens to win from Hellas, by helping a man of worth. This is the return that I will make you for saving me, for now you are in need of friends. But when the gods honor a man, he has no need of friends; for the god's aid, when he chooses to give it, is enough.

1340

HERACLES: No! this is quite beside the question of my troubles. For my part, I do not believe that the gods indulge in unholy unions; and as for putting bonds on hands, I have never thought that worthy of credit nor will I now be so persuaded, nor again that one god is naturally lord and master of another. For the deity, if he be really such, has no wants; these are miserable tales of the poets. But I, for all my piteous plight, reflected whether I should let myself be branded as a coward for giving up my life. For whoever does not withstand disasters will never be able to withstand even a man's weapon. I will be steadfast in living; I will go to your city, with grateful thanks for all you offer me.

1353

HERACLES: But I have tasted of countless troubles, as is well known; never yet did I faint at any or shed a single tear; no, nor did I ever

think that I should come to this, to let the tear-drop fall. But now, it seems, I must be fortune's slave. Well, let it pass; my old father, you see me go forth to exile, and in me you see my own children's murderer. Give them burial, and lay them out in death with the tribute of a tear, for the law forbids my doing so. Rest their heads upon their mother's bosom and fold them in her arms, sad fellowship, which I, alas! unwittingly did slay. And when you have buried these dead, live on here still, in bitterness maybe, but still constrain your soul to share my sorrows. O children! he who begot you, your own father, has been your destroyer, and you have had no profit of my triumphs, all my restless toil to win for you by force a fair name, a glorious advantage from a father. You too, unhappy wife, this hand has slain, a poor return to make you for preserving the honor of my bed so safely, for all the weary watch you long have kept within my house. Alas for you, my wife, my sons! alas for me, how sad my lot, cut off from wife and child! Ah! these kisses, bitter-sweet! these weapons which it is pain to own! I am not sure whether to keep or let them go; dangling at my side they thus will say, "With us you destroyed children and wife; we are your children's slayers, and you keep us." Shall I carry them after that? what answer can I make? Yet, am I to strip myself of these weapons, the comrades of my glorious career in Hellas, and put myself in the power of my foes, to die a death of shame? No! I must not let them go, but keep them, though it grieves me. In one thing, Theseus, help my misery; come to Argos and help me to manage the conveyance of the wretched dog; lest, if I go all alone, my sorrow for my sons may do me some hurt. O land of Cadmus, and all you people of Thebes! cut off your hair, and mourn with me; go to my children's burial, and with one dirge lament us all, the dead and me; for on all of us has Hera inflicted the same cruel blow of destruction.

1394

THESEUS: Rise, unhappy man! you have had your fill of tears.

1395

HERACLES: I cannot rise; my limbs are rooted here.

1396

THESEUS: Yes, even the strong are overthrown by misfortunes.

1397

HERACLES: Ah! Would I could become a stone upon this spot, oblivious of trouble.

1398

THESEUS: Peace! give your hand to a friend and helper.

1399

HERACLES: No, let me not wipe off the blood upon your robe.

1400

THESEUS: Wipe it off and spare not; I will not refuse you.

1401

HERACLES: Bereft of my own sons, I find you as a son to me.

1402

THESEUS: Throw your arm about my neck; I will be your guide.

1403

HERACLES: A pair of friends indeed, but one a man of sorrows. Ah! aged father, this is the kind of man to make a friend.

1405

AMPHITRYON: Blessed in her sons, the country that gave him birth!

1406

HERACLES: Theseus, turn me back again to see my children.

1407

THESEUS: What for? Do you think to find a drug in this to soothe your soul?

1408

HERACLES: I long to do so, and would embrace my father.

1409

AMPHITRYON: Here am I, my son; your wish is no less dear to me.

1410

THESEUS: Have you so short a memory for your troubles?

1411

HERACLES: All that I endured before was easier to bear than this.

1412

THESEUS: If anyone sees you play the woman, they will scoff.

1413

HERACLES: Have I by living grown so abject in your sight? It was not so once, I think.

1414

THESEUS: Yes, too much so; in your sickness you are not the glorious Heracles.

1415

HERACLES: What about you? What kind of hero were you when in trouble in the world below?

1416

THESEUS: I was worse than anyone as far as courage went.

1417

HERACLES: How then can you say of me, that I am abased by my troubles?

1418

THESEUS: Forward!

HERACLES: Farewell, my aged father!

AMPHITRYON: Farewell to you, my son!

1419

HERACLES: Bury my children as I said.

AMPHITRYON: But who will bury me, my son?

1420

HERACLES: I will.

AMPHITRYON: When will you come?

HERACLES: After you have buried my children.

1421

AMPHITRYON: How?

HERACLES: I will fetch you from Thebes to Athens. But carry my children within, a grievous burden to the earth. And I, after ruining my house by deeds of shame, will follow as a little boat in the wake of Theseus, a total wreck. Whoever prefers wealth or might to the possession of good friends, thinks wrongly.

1427

CHORUS: With grief and many a bitter tear we go our way, robbed of all we prized most dearly.